have access to a range of nuclear, defence, and dual-use technologies (which could serve both military and civilian purposes). The solution would be to create an exception for India in US law and at international export control entities such as the Nuclear Suppliers Group, while getting India to harmonize its export controls with international standards. In the aftermath of India's nuclear test, a proposal for a similar exception had been floated by the Indian government. Several other countries, notably France, had openly talked about such a possibility. But many in the US establishment were sceptical, believing that a civilian nuclear agreement with India would compromise Washington's relations with China and Pakistan, provoke an arms race, and set a negative precedent for international non-proliferation efforts by appearing to 'reward' India. [37]

The US efforts to increase India's access to sensitive technology were incremental between 2001 and 2004, embodied in a set of initiatives known as the Next Steps in Strategic Partnership (NSSP), whose objective was to gradually reduce export controls to India in critical areas, including defence, space, and nuclear technology. [38] During his second term beginning in 2004, President George W. Bush and his advisors opted for a more ambitious proposal that the Manmohan Singh government had also been advocating. This was the landmark India–US civilian nuclear agreement, announced on 18 July 2005 by the two leaders in Washington, DC. Essentially, this was an agreement to let India preserve its nuclear weapon arsenal while receiving access to US and international commerce, as well as technology for energy and other peaceful purposes. In exchange, India would have to separate its military and civilian nuclear programmes and place the latter under safeguards in line with standard international practice. [39] While the Clinton administration had demanded five criteria for the lifting of sanctions after 1998, Bush was asking for only one (harmonization of export controls) in exchange for international acceptance of India as a de facto nuclear weapon power. The next three years saw considerable attention and resources devoted to finalizing and implementing this agreement, which faced significant opposition in both countries. In India, the political opposition, some nuclear scientists, and the